

PREPARED FOR BEN PICKRELL, ARI ATHLETICS

Build the ARI Athletics marketing team you **never had**

A marketing team, built for ARI Athletics and handed over. First a practical, empirically solid marketing strategy and execution plan, built to create fame fast on controlling technology costs. Then the AI systems to run it at quality and speed, a range scoped together. Then a fractional CMO to keep it improving. This is the plan, and how it works.



Quality first, then automate



IRELAND'S MARKETER OF THE YEAR, 2022

Before I build anything, I ask one question: what does really good look like here? Not what AI can do, but the best version of this marketing, and the level of quality I would want to stand over.

So I start where I always have. If there were no AI at all, what team would I hire to do this properly? A strategist to set the positioning and the plan, someone building your authority in public, and someone running the campaigns and keeping score. I map that team first, then build exactly it, with agents instead of hires.

Twenty years in brand is what tells me where the bar sits: Head of Brand at O2 Ireland, then CMO at the National Lottery, Head of Brand at Indeed and Miro, both global roles. Positioning, messaging and tone are written first, then built into everything the agents make.

WHO I WORK WITH

Moloco

Heineken

Norcros

Alltech

Smurfit

Hostelworld

Eaton Square

Weatherbys

"His command of marketing science as well as his instincts for great thinking and ideas are, in my opinion, superb."

Peter Field · The Godfather of Effectiveness, author of The Long and the Short of It

"Paul reported into me as Head of Brand when I was at Indeed. I have learned more from him than anyone else in my career."

Paul D'Arcy · CMO, Moloco. Former CMO at Miro and Indeed

What we would build for ARI

This comes from our conversation. ARI sells to a defined market: roughly a thousand US colleges are a realistic fit, out of about two thousand with athletics programmes, and you already hold that list. Every college publishes its athletics staff directory publicly, so the right people at each one can be identified without buying data. Because the list is finite, the work is not about reaching more people. It is about reaching the right people at the right moment, and building familiarity with the rest so that ARI is considered when they do start looking.

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- 01 **Positioning and messaging.** We agree how ARI is described and sold: what the product does, which colleges it is for, and how to answer a buyer comparing you with a larger platform or with keeping things as they are. This is written down as a short set of messages, and everything we build afterwards uses them.
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- 02 **The Outbound Agent.** This is the work of contacting a college properly. It finds the right person in the college's published athletics staff directory, researches them and how their department currently runs recruiting, and writes a message that could only have been sent to them, on email or LinkedIn. You review everything before it goes out. It works from the college list you already hold, so there is no data to buy and no period spent building a list.
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- 03 **The website, and a page for each prospect.** You asked how we build websites with AI, so the web version of this proposal includes ARI rebuilt from your current site. Building this way means a landing page written for one specific college takes minutes, so when a prospect looks ARI up, the page they arrive at can address their situation.
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- 04 **Scout.** The Outbound Agent decides how well a college is contacted. Scout decides when. It watches all thousand colleges and waits for a real buying signal: a new athletic director is appointed, a president starts asking for recruiting data the department cannot produce, a recruiting role is advertised, or a competitor raises its price at renewal. It then hands that college to the Outbound Agent. In most weeks most of the list produces no signal, and nothing is sent.
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- 05 **A content programme.** Only a small number of the thousand colleges are considering a purchase in any quarter. Publishing ARI's view on the questions athletic directors and coaches actually deal with means that when one of them does start looking, ARI is already a name they know rather than a stranger getting in touch.
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The parts, and what each one is for

STEP ONE

Positioning and messaging

We would begin by agreeing how ARI is described and sold, because every other piece of work depends on it. That means deciding what ARI does that the alternatives do not, which colleges it is for, and how to answer a buyer who is weighing you against a larger platform or against keeping their current arrangements. We write this down as a short set of messages, and the outreach, the website and the content all use them.

The substance for this already exists. ARI works only with college athletic departments, and only at Division III and NAIA level. Support is close because the company is small, and the price does not rise sharply at renewal. None of that is currently on your website, and the line you lead with, level up your recruiting, could be used by any competitor. The stronger position is the one you described on our call: athletics and admissions normally work from separate records, and ARI puts them on the same one.

Related reading: [The 95:5 rule, the day-one list](#) · [What is mental availability](#)

STEP TWO

The Outbound Agent

Contacting a thousand colleges properly is a job a person does, and doing it well has traditionally required a full-time hire, an agency, or a freelancer. The Outbound Agent carries out that job. For each college it identifies the right person from the published athletics staff directory, researches them and how their department currently runs recruiting, and writes a message to that one person that could not have been sent to anyone else. It works on email and on LinkedIn, and nothing is sent until you have read it.

It works from the list you already hold, so there is no data to buy and no period spent finding people before anything can happen. That matters here because the list is finite. You get one chance at a first approach to each college, so the quality of each message is worth more than the number of messages sent.

STEP THREE

The website

Building a website has traditionally required a designer, a front end developer, and someone to manage both. We do that work with AI, which is what you asked about on the call. Rather than describe it, the web version of this proposal contains ARI rebuilt from your current site, so you can judge the standard and the speed yourself. To be clear about what it is: it was produced in minutes with no brief, working only from the content already on your site. A real project would involve a proper brief, the right photography, agreed navigation and written content.

Two issues came up while building it, and both are worth fixing regardless of whether we work together. Your email domain and your website domain are different, so a college that receives a message from arierecruiting.com and arrives at ARI Athletics has to work out that they are the same company. And www.ariathletics.com does not load, because the security certificate does not cover the www version of the address. The address without www works normally.

Related reading: [Dump your website and start again](#)

STEP FOUR

Scout

The Outbound Agent decides how well a college is contacted. Scout decides when. It watches all thousand colleges on the list and waits for a genuine buying signal: a new athletic director is appointed, a college president or VP of enrolment starts asking for recruiting data the department cannot produce, a recruiting or athletics role is advertised, or a competitor raises its price at renewal. You have already won a customer that last way, when a large competitor put its price up at the end of a three year contract.

When a signal appears, Scout checks that the college has not already been contacted, and hands it to the Outbound Agent, which does the research and writes the message. You approve the shortlist before anything is sent. In most weeks most of the list produces no signal at all and nothing goes out, which is the system working asintended. A college contacted for no reason is less likely to pay attention when there is one.

The content programme

When a college decides to look for a system, it usually already has a small number of suppliers in mind, formed before the search began. It is difficult to be added to that list once the process has started. This is the point you recognised on our call.

The content programme publishes ARI's view on the questions athletic directors and coaches actually deal with, in ARI's name, with you approving everything before it goes out. When a college does start looking, ARI is then a name they already know rather than a stranger getting in touch.

Related reading: [How I build an AI writer](#)

Two options

Option A is the smaller piece of work, and it is designed to generate enquiries from the colleges that are actively looking now. Option B includes all of Option A and adds the work that builds familiarity with the colleges that are not yet looking, so that ARI is considered when they are. We would recommend starting with Option A. It is quicker, the results are measurable, and it gives you a clear view of how we work before committing to the larger programme.

OPTION A · THE DEMAND ENGINE

Generate enquiries from colleges that are looking now

- › Positioning and messaging: how ARI is described, who it is for, and how it answers the alternatives
- › An outreach system on email and LinkedIn, working from the college list you already hold, so there is no data to buy
- › A landing page produced for each prospect, so that what they see when they look ARI up addresses their situation
- › Everything configured for ARI, handed over, and documented so your team can run it

€7,500 exclusive of any applicable taxes

Two to three weeks from sign-off. Your own tool subscriptions are separate, in your name, sized with you first.

OPTION B · THE WHOLE SYSTEM

The full programme, including the colleges not yet in the market

- › Everything in Option A
- › A new website, rebuilt so that you control it and the landing pages run from it
- › **Scout**, which watches all thousand colleges and tells the Outbound Agent when one is worth writing to: a new athletic director, a president asking for recruiting data, a role advertised, or a competitor raising its price at renewal
- › A content programme, published in ARI's name, so that athletic directors and coaches become familiar with ARI before they need to buy
- › Direct mail to the colleges where it is worth the cost, which is practical because the list is small and known

€40,000 exclusive of any applicable

taxes

About two months. A Search Agent, to get ARI surfaced inside the answers AI tools give, can be added and would be scoped separately.

WHAT THE PRICE COVERS

The strategy and plan, the AI systems built to run it, the handover and the training, then a senior head kept on the work every month. You own the system and the strategy it runs on.

WHAT IT DOESN'T

Your own tool subscriptions: Claude Code, hosting and the email platform, which stay in your name and your ownership. A modest, predictable software bill, sized and agreed with you before a euro is spent.

Book a time to chat

Thirty minutes is enough to talk it through. Book a time at cal.com/paul-dervan-mjfd50, or email me directly at paul@runwithfoxes.com.